Unit 13: Ruba'iyat (Poem)

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. What does Allama Muhammad Iqbal mean by describing faith as being "God-drunk"?

• "God-drunk" is a paradox that blends intoxication (usually negative) with divine ecstasy (positive). It describes a state of total absorption in the love and devotion of Allah (SWT).

• The God-drunk believer is so absorbed in faith that he loses himself in it, just as a drunk person loses self-control. But unlike worldly intoxication, this absorption is honourable — it is "self-honouring" because it comes from the highest devotion.

• Iqbal uses the image of Hazrat Abraham (AS) at the stake to show what God-drunk faith looks like: a willingness to endure fire rather than compromise faith.

Q2. Why does the poet claim that having no faith is "worse than slavery"?

• Slavery is physical bondage — the body is chained, but the soul can remain free. A slave can still believe, hope, and resist inwardly.

• Having no faith is a form of spiritual bankruptcy. Without faith, a person has no inner strength, no honour, and no purpose. He becomes a slave to his own desires, to materialism, and to the culture of others.

• Iqbal therefore says faithlessness is worse than slavery because the faithless person is chained from within.

Q3. How does Allama Muhammad Iqbal contrast "music of strange lands" with "Islam's fire"?

• "Music of strange lands" represents Western culture, materialism, and foreign values that captivate the modern Muslim. It is attractive but alien.

• "Islam's fire" represents the energy, passion, and spiritual vitality of Islam. Fire is warm, powerful, and life-giving. The nation's harmony depends on this fire, not on foreign music.

• The contrast is between imitation and identity. Iqbal warns that blending foreign culture with Islam weakens the nation.

Q4. What phrases show Allama Muhammad Iqbal's view of European civilization as spiritually empty?

• Iqbal calls Europe's soul "empty of concord" — harmony and unity of hearts and purpose are absent, even though Europe has material progress.

• He says Europe's civilisation "to no Makkah bends" — it does not submit to or respect Islamic values.

• The juxtaposition is clear: Europe has material civilisation but no spiritual concord, while Islam has the fire that gives a nation harmony.

Q5. How does the poet portray the spiritual condition of contemporary Muslims?

• Iqbal portrays contemporary Muslims as spiritually weakened. "Love's madness has departed" — the passion of faith is gone.

• "In the Muslim's veins the blood runs thin" — a physiological metaphor for weakened spiritual vitality.

• "Ranks broken, hearts perplexed, prayers cold" — unity is lost, hearts are confused, and worship has become hollow ritual. "No feeling deeper than the skin" — Muslims now live only on the surface.

Q6. Identify and explain two metaphors used to describe Muslim decline.

• (1) "In the Muslim's veins the blood runs thin" — a physiological metaphor showing weakened spiritual vitality, as thin blood lacks strength.

• (2) "Prayers cold" — a thermal metaphor showing that worship has lost its warmth and feeling, becoming hollow ritual.

• Both metaphors map spiritual states onto physical images, making the decline vivid and memorable.

Q7. How does the concept of "Love's madness" relate to Allama Muhammad Iqbal's idea of Khudi (selfhood)?

• Khudi (selfhood) is Iqbal's call for Muslims to awaken, discover their identity, and act with passion and purpose. "Love's madness" is the emotional energy of Khudi — an intense, passionate devotion that drives a person to action.

• When love's madness departs, Khudi dies. The Muslim becomes passive, imitative, and spiritually weak.

• Thus "Love's madness" is not insanity; it is sacred passion. Iqbal wants Muslims to recover it so that their Khudi can rise again.

Q8. Do you agree with Allama Muhammad Iqbal's diagnosis of modern spiritual problems? Why?

• Yes, I agree to a large extent. Iqbal's diagnosis — that material progress without spiritual values leaves a civilisation empty — is visible today. Societies that chase wealth and technology often face loneliness, loss of identity, and moral confusion.

• His warning about imitation is also relevant: nations that copy foreign cultures without keeping their own values lose their harmony and unity.

• However, one might add that Iqbal's call is not against knowledge or progress itself, but against progress without faith. His solution is revival through Khudi, not rejection of the modern world.

Exercise B — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	What does the metaphor "Abraham at the stake" primarily represent in the poem?	c. unwavering faith in God [Allah (SWT)]
2	The phrase "God-drunk" in the poem means:	a. religious intoxication (absorption in divine devotion)
3	What does "music of strange lands" represent in the poem?	a. European art/culture (Western civilisation)
4	The phrase "to no Makkah bends" implies that European civilization:	b. rejects divine guidance (does not submit to Islamic values)
5	What does "blood runs thin" metaphorically represent?	b. loss of spiritual vitality

Exercise C — Literary Devices in the Lines (Answers)

Line	Literary Device
"Self-honouring and God-drunk is faith"	Paradox / oxymoron ("God-drunk")
"Music of strange lands with Islam's fire blends"	Metaphor and juxtaposition (foreign culture vs. Islamic passion)
"Empty of concord is the soul of Europe"	Metaphor (Europe's soul described as empty)
"The Muslim's veins the blood runs thin"	Physiological metaphor
"No feeling deeper than the skin"	Metaphor (superficiality)
"Whose civilization to no Makkah bends"	Symbolism (Makkah as submission to Allah)

Vocabulary Exercises (Answers)

• **Dictionary information (model):** Ruba'iyat (noun) — a poetic form consisting of quatrains. God-drunk (adjective) — intoxicated with divine love. Captivate (verb) — to charm or dominate attention. Concord (noun) — harmony or agreement.

• **Synonyms (model):** captivate — charm, fascinate; concord — harmony, unity; perplexed — confused, bewildered; madness — passion, zeal.

• **Sentences:** The ruba'iyat of Iqbal are famous. The Sufi was God-drunk in his devotion. The story captivated the audience. Concord among the ranks made the nation strong.

Writing Tasks — Model Answers

A. Descriptive Composition: An Islamic Figure of "God-Drunk" Faith

• **Brainstorming:** Hazrat Ibrahim (AS) — fearless, standing alone against Nimrod's fire; unmatched tawakkul (trust in Allah); proof that true power lies in submission, not swords or thrones. Hazrat Imam Hussain (RA) — sacrificing everything at Karbala for justice.

• **First draft (model):** "When Nimrod ordered the fire to be kindled for Hazrat Ibrahim (AS), the young prophet did not tremble. He was God-drunk — absorbed in the love of Allah (SWT) — and walked towards the flames with self-honouring faith. The fire, by the command of Allah, became cool and safe for him. His fearlessness was not the courage of a soldier but the certainty of a believer. He stood alone against a king, an army, and a nation of idol-worshippers, yet he did not bend. His story proves that true power lies in submission to Allah, not in swords or thrones."

• **Revision:** Check spellings and punctuation; employ figurative language (e.g., "a mountain of faith," "the fire became a garden").

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